

Venue booking platform for The Playhouse Company

A working booking platform for all fourteen Playhouse venues — public hire pages, online payment, an approvals workflow for the theatres, operational reporting and a booking assistant on web and WhatsApp. Built and demonstrable today; the items it still needs are commercial, not technical.

Status as at 18 August 2026 · prepared for proposal drafting

14 venues	1 224 seats	6 reports	5 staff roles
across 4 categories	largest house (Opera)	each exporting to CSV	separately permissioned

Scope — what the platform does

Three audiences are served by one system, all reading and writing the same booking record.

For the customer

Browse venues by category, see live availability, hold a slot, and pay online. Day-rate venues are chosen by date; hourly venues by a time grid. A hold lasts **20 minutes** and is plainly labelled as not yet a booking. Customers can look up a booking by reference, pay an outstanding balance, and request a cancellation without phoning anyone.

For The Playhouse Company

An administration console covering bookings, approvals, payments and refunds, a venue calendar, venue and tariff management, operating hours, closures for public holidays and productions, and staff user management. Every consequential action is written to an audit trail against the person who took it.

Booking assistant

A conversational assistant on the website and on WhatsApp that can find a venue, check real availability, hold dates and start a booking, handing over a payment link. It never quotes a price or a date it has not looked up, never takes card details, and cannot confirm a booking itself — payment and approval remain the only routes to confirmation.

Commercial model — venues and how each is sold

The tariff structure is already modelled per venue, including which need management approval and which accept a deposit. Rates below are the seeded figures and should be checked against the current tariff schedule before the proposal quotes them.

VENUE	CAPACITY	SOLD BY	RATE	CONFIRMATION	PAYMENT
THEATRES					
Opera	1 224	Day	R27 000	Approval	Deposit 50%
Drama	468	Day	R15 000	Approval	Deposit 50%

VENUE	CAPACITY	SOLD BY	RATE	CONFIRMATION	PAYMENT
Loft	136	Day	R6 500	Approval	Full upfront
FUNCTION VENUES					
Grand Foyer	300	Day	R27 000	Approval	Deposit 40%
Tudor Room	100	Day	R28 000	Approval	Deposit 40%
Alhambra	100	Day	R14 000	Approval	Deposit 40%
VIP Room	10	Day	R4 000	Approval	Full upfront
REHEARSAL VENUES					
Room 503	120	Hour	R390	Instant	Full upfront
Room 410	60	Hour	R340	Instant	Full upfront
Room A1	60	Hour	R260	Instant	Full upfront
Rooms 506 / 507 / 508	—	Hour	R110	Instant	Full upfront
RECORDING STUDIO					
Studio 3	—	Hour	R650	Instant	Full upfront

All rates VAT-inclusive. Capacity is not yet captured for four venues.

Worth making a point of. Double bookings are prevented by the database itself, not by application checks that can race under load. Turnaround buffers before and after each hire are enforced the same way, so a venue cannot be sold twice even if two customers press pay at the same instant.

Commercial dependency — payments

All four South African gateways named in the RFP are implemented. Switching between them is a configuration change, not development work, so the choice can be deferred until merchant accounts are settled. None has been tested against live credentials, because none exist yet.

GATEWAY	POSITION	STATUS
PayFast	Production candidate	Awaiting credentials
Yoco	Production candidate	Awaiting credentials
Paystack	Production candidate	Awaiting credentials
iKhokha	Production candidate	Awaiting credentials
EFT	Manual capture by finance	Working
Stripe	Demonstration only — not proposed	Runnable today

Stripe exists so the full payment lifecycle can be shown before merchant onboarding. It is not the production path.

Deposits and balances are handled end to end: a deposit booking tracks what remains, finance can request the balance, and the customer pays it from a link. Refunds run through the gateway where the provider supports it and are recorded manually where it does not, so an EFT refund still reaches the customer's ledger.

A booking does not depend on a webhook arriving. When the customer returns from the payment page the platform queries the gateway directly, and a nightly job reconciles anyone who closed the tab. Unpaid bookings release their venue automatically after **60 minutes**.

Scope — integrations and channels

CAPABILITY	WHAT IT DOES	STATUS
Website embed	The booking portal runs inside an iframe on the existing Playhouse site, with no second design to maintain	Built
Transactional email	Eleven templates — confirmations, tax invoices, approval notices, cancellations, refunds, password resets — every message logged with its delivery outcome and retried on failure	Sender setup pending
Outlook calendars	Confirmed bookings appear on each venue's resource mailbox via Microsoft Graph, so operations see the same occupancy the platform enforces	Needs tenant access
Calendar subscription	A per-venue feed any calendar application can subscribe to, protected by its own token	Built
WhatsApp assistant	The same booking assistant over WhatsApp Cloud API, with verified message signatures	Needs Meta account
Newsletter capture	Opt-in sign-up with the date consent was recorded, as POPIA requires	Built

Scope — reporting and access

Six operational reports, each filterable by date range and exportable to CSV: bookings by venue, revenue by venue, customer booking history, cancelled bookings, outstanding payments, and venue utilisation. The venue schedule also exports for distribution to staff.

Five roles keep duties separated — **customer**, **front desk** (read-only operational access), **venue manager** (approves only their assigned venues), **finance** (payments, refunds, financial reports) and **administrator**. Venue managers see only what they are responsible for.

Compliance — regulatory position

- **VAT.** The published tariff is VAT-inclusive, so the VAT portion is extracted for the tax invoice rather than added to the price. The rate and registration number are stamped onto each invoice, so a future rate change cannot alter a historical one.
- **Conditions of hire.** The version a customer accepted is recorded against their booking with the moment they accepted it, so a later revision never changes what was agreed.
- **POPIA.** A privacy notice is published and discloses the three cookies the platform sets, all of them strictly necessary. No analytics or advertising trackers are used, so no consent banner is required. Card details never touch the platform.
- **Audit trail.** Approvals, rejections, cancellations, refunds and manual payments are all recorded against the staff member who performed them.

Risk — what is outstanding

The platform refuses to start in production while any of these is unresolved — a deliberate guard, so it cannot go live quietly taking simulated payments. None is development work.

ITEM	WHAT IS NEEDED	OWNER
Merchant account	A state-registered merchant facility with one of the four gateways, then credentials	The Playhouse Company
VAT registration number	Required by SARS on every valid tax invoice	The Playhouse Company
Conditions of hire	Ten clauses still marked draft and awaiting confirmation, yet customers are asked to accept them	The Playhouse Company
Live domain	The address customers use, since payment return links are built from it	Joint
Staff account passwords	Five seeded accounts still use the published demonstration password	Joint
Mail sending	Sender domain is authenticated; the relay's IP restriction still blocks delivery from the hosting platform	Service provider
Venue copy and capacity	Ten venue descriptions are placeholders; capacity missing for four	The Playhouse Company
Microsoft 365 / Meta	Tenant access for Outlook sync and a Business account for WhatsApp, both optional at launch	The Playhouse Company

Delivery — points to carry into the proposal

The build is done; the dependencies are commercial

Every outstanding item is a credential, a signature or a piece of copy. That is a favourable position to write from, and worth stating plainly rather than burying in a risk register.

Gateway choice can be deferred

Because all four are implemented, the proposal can commit to whichever acquirer the merchant bank arrangement favours without re-quoting development.

Approval workflow matches how the venues actually trade

Theatres and function venues require management approval; rehearsal rooms and the studio confirm on payment. This mirrors existing practice rather than imposing a new one.

Hosting has a cost step worth flagging

The current plan limits scheduled maintenance to once daily and functions to sixty seconds. Nothing depends on it for correctness, but the next tier allows a five-minute cycle and should be priced if the client wants it.

Recommend a staging period before trading

Once merchant credentials arrive, run live gateway tests and real email delivery on a staging deployment that takes no real bookings. Build the time into the schedule.

Prepared from the working codebase and its live database on 18 August 2026. Figures are demonstration data; tariffs, capacities and venue copy require confirmation from The Playhouse Company before publication.